

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN LESOTHO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes project outcomes in Lesotho, and this guide begins with an honest truth that makes it different from the others. Sometimes a project cannot be stopped — and Lesotho's most famous fight is the proof, and also the model for what you can still win when stopping is impossible. The **Lesotho Highlands Water Project**, a chain of five dams and two hundred kilometres of tunnels through the Maluti Mountains built to sell water to South Africa's industrial heartland, was bound by a treaty with a far more powerful neighbour and backed by the World Bank; the highland communities in its path could not halt it, and were displaced. But Lesotho did something no developing country had ever done. It **exposed and criminally prosecuted the corruption behind the project** — convicting the project's own chief executive of taking bribes, and then convicting the great multinational firms that had paid them: a Canadian company, a German one, a French one, an Italian one — and pressing the World Bank to **debar** the worst of them. A tiny, poor kingdom put the world's construction giants in the dock and won. And the affected communities, though they could not stop the dams, fought on for the compensation, the resettlement, and the rights they were owed. The scale of the thing is worth setting down. The Highlands project is one of the largest infrastructure schemes in Africa, conceived under a 1986 treaty to store water in the mountains of Lesotho and send it north to the industrial region around Johannesburg, hundreds of millions of cubic metres a year, in exchange for royalties and a hydropower plant. Two of its dams and the power component were built at a cost of some three and a half billion dollars, funded in part by the World Bank. For a small, poor country, refusing such a project — desired by its powerful neighbour and its own government alike — was never realistic; what was possible, and what Lesotho achieved, was to make the corruption behind it answer in a court of law.

The Lesotho story teaches two things about fighting here — including its hard limits, which this guide states at the outset rather than hiding. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected communities, the documentation, the coalition, the courts, the financier, the international cooperation, and the world's attention — pressed together. The second is distinctly Lesotho, and hard-won. **When a project is driven by a treaty, a powerful neighbour, and foreign money, and cannot be stopped, the fight shifts to accountability and to terms:** to exposing and prosecuting the corruption behind it, to pressing the financiers to debar the corrupt contractors, and to winning the compensation, resettlement, and rights the affected people deserve. That accountability model — the world's iconic example of holding a mega-project's corruption criminally to account — is Lesotho's distinctive contribution, and this guide is built around both goals: stopping a project where you can, and, where you cannot, making the corruption pay and the affected people whole. It is worth being clear about how unusual this was. Before Lesotho, the multinational firms that built the world's great dams and infrastructure had rarely, if ever, been criminally convicted in the country where they paid their bribes; corruption was treated as the cost of doing business, prosecuted, if at all, only in the rich home countries of the firms. A tiny mountain kingdom broke that pattern — auditing its own authority, prosecuting its own official, and then convicting the foreign giants themselves — and in doing so it wrote a template that anti-corruption campaigners the world over have studied ever since.

The honest limits are therefore woven through this guide from the first page. The dams **were built**; the highland communities **were displaced**; the compensation has often been **inadequate and delayed**, and the fight for it continues. Accountability, however historic, **does not restore** a flooded valley or a lost livelihood. Lesotho is small, poor, water-rich, and bound to a **treaty with South Africa** it had little power to refuse. The asymmetry could hardly be starker: on one side a landlocked country of a couple of million people, among the poorest on the continent, whose chief exportable resource is the water that falls on its highlands; on the other, the largest economy in Africa, whose industrial and urban heartland cannot function without that water. A treaty between such unequal parties is not easily unmade by the villagers whose valleys it floods, and any guide that told them otherwise would be lying. The honesty of this guide is to say plainly that the dam will likely be built — and then to show what can still be won. And the state is weak. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a community that, unable to stop a project, exposes its corruption and fights for its people's due — and the sober reality that some projects, in a small country tied to a powerful neighbour, are not stopped at all.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition or accountability effective. They discover a project already agreed by treaty and government, assume "the powerful have decided and nothing can be done," and never document the harm, never expose the corruption, never press the financier, never organise for compensation, never build the coalition. They generate private loss without a public claim. The gap between a community that wins something and one

that wins nothing is rarely courage — Basotho have defended their highlands with courage. It is method: knowing that even a project you cannot stop can be made to answer for its corruption and to pay what it owes.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Lesotho system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a project or, where that is impossible, to hold it to account and win fair terms:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the decision, the corruption, and the weak point)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build proof of harm, of corruption, and of what is owed)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(build the coalition of the affected)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES	(the courts, the corruption, the financier, and compensation)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(make it national and international)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the corruption case, the compensation claim, and the public argument at once; the coalition sustains the pressure; a prosecution or a debarment is a headline and a headline builds the movement. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a stop where possible, and accountability and fair terms where not. The Lesotho fight did exactly this — it audited and documented, exposed the corruption, prosecuted the firms and the official, pressed the World Bank to debar, organised the affected, and carried the fight to the world.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Lesotho's give communities a distinctive set — especially where a project cannot be stopped:

- **Criminal accountability for corruption.** Lesotho showed that a poor country can **prosecute and convict** both its own corrupt officials and the multinational firms that bribed them — the world's landmark example. The Lesotho convictions were comprehensive: the project's chief executive was imprisoned, and a Canadian firm, a German firm, a French firm, and an Italian firm were convicted or pleaded guilty, along with an intermediary who had funnelled the payments. That a national court reached not only the local official who took the bribes but the wealthy foreign corporations that paid them is what made the case a global landmark, because it established that the firms, not just their victims' governments, could be held criminally responsible where the corruption occurred.
- **Financier debarment.** Pressing the **World Bank and other financiers to debar** corrupt contractors, as Lesotho did with Acres and Lahmeyer, punishes them far beyond one project. Debarment is a distinct and underused weapon, and worth understanding: a development bank that finds a contractor corrupt can bar it from bidding on any bank-financed project for a period of years, which for a firm that lives on such contracts is a punishment often heavier than a fine. After the Lesotho convictions, the World Bank debarred both the Canadian and the German firm, a signal to the whole industry that the corruption uncovered in one small country could cost a contractor its business worldwide — and a lever any campaign that has proven corruption should reach for.
- **International legal cooperation. Mutual legal assistance** — from Switzerland, from European anti-fraud bodies — can trace the bribes and enable the prosecutions.
- **The fight for compensation and rights.** Where a project proceeds, organised communities can press for **fair compensation, resettlement, and rehabilitation**, and hold the authority to its obligations.
- **The world's attention.** A mega-project's corruption and its human cost draw international scrutiny that strengthens every other lever.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers stop projects. Lesotho's own landmark **did not stop the dams**; it made their corruption pay. Compensation has been **inadequate and slow**. A **treaty and a powerful neighbour** can put a project beyond a small country's power to refuse. And accountability, however historic, **does not undo** the harm. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — stopping a project where you can, and, where you cannot, exposing and prosecuting the corruption, debarring the contractors, and winning the compensation and rights the affected people are owed, as Lesotho did.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision — or the accountability — is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Lesotho development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The treaty and the government. The largest projects rest on **treaties and government agreements** — as the Highlands Water Project rests on a treaty with South Africa — which can put the decision itself beyond easy reach. This level is often the proponent, and often immovable. Understanding this early spares a community a wasteful and demoralising campaign: where a project is fixed by an international treaty between states, no amount of local protest is likely to unmake the agreement, and the energy spent demanding that it be cancelled is energy not spent on the accountability and compensation that can actually be won. The strategic maturity of the Lesotho approach lay precisely in accepting the immovable and concentrating force on the movable.

The authority and the contractors. A **development authority** (like the LHDA) and its **multinational contractors** run the project — and are where corruption, and therefore accountability, are found.

The financiers. The **World Bank and other financiers** fund the project and are bound by their own **anti-corruption and debarment rules** — a distinct and powerful lever. This is a pressure point the government and the contractors cannot control, and it operates by rules written in the financier's own policies rather than in Lesotho's law: a bank that has financed a project it later learns was corrupt faces its own reputational and institutional interest in being seen to act, and a campaign that presents it with proof of corruption — better still, with convictions — gives it both the grounds and the incentive to debar. The financier, in short, answers to a logic the local proponents do not.

The courts. Lesotho's **courts** proved able to convict corrupt officials and multinational firms — a real lever for accountability, if not always for stopping.

The affected communities and civil society. The **displaced and affected communities, the churches, and civil society** are the force that documents the harm, fights for compensation, and rouses the world.

The Journey of a Project

A typical large project moves from a **treaty or agreement**, through a **development authority** and its **contractors**, funded by **financiers**, toward construction and the displacement of communities — with the affected people, the courts, and the world able to **expose corruption, press the financiers, and fight for compensation** at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in** — though, honestly, the earliest doors may be shut by treaty. Where the project cannot be stopped, the widest doors are the distinctive Lesotho ones: **the corruption and its prosecution, the financier's debarment, and the fight for compensation and rights**. Find out exactly where your project stands — and, above all, **whether corruption drove it and what the affected people are owed**, because those are often the winnable fights.

Follow the Treaty, the Money, and the Harm

Behind the project stand a proponent — often the government and a development authority — its **multinational contractors**, its **financiers**, and the officials who ran it. Trace who profits, who decided, who built it, and — critically in Lesotho — **whether corruption drove the contracts** (as bribes drove the Highlands contracts), **what the project does to the highland communities**, and **what compensation and rehabilitation they are owed**. Two questions unlock most Lesotho fights: **Was the project corrupt, and can that be proven and prosecuted?** and **What are the displaced and affected people owed, and is the authority meeting it?** The corruption and the compensation are, together, the heart of most Lesotho campaigns — because they are what can be won even when the project cannot be stopped. The two are linked in a hard way: it is often the very corruption that inflated the contracts and enriched the officials that left too little, and too little honestly administered, for the compensation the displaced were promised, so that exposing the theft and demanding the redress are parts of a single story — the money that should have resettled a flooded village went instead into a numbered account abroad. A campaign that tells that story whole, the bribe and the unpaid compensation together, is far more powerful than one that treats them as separate grievances.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts**, which convicted the corrupt; the **financiers' anti-corruption and debarment mechanisms**; the **international anti-fraud and mutual-legal-assistance bodies** that trace the bribes; the **churches, civil society, and international NGOs** that document the

harm and fight for compensation; and the **world's press**. In Lesotho, the **courts and the financiers' debarment** are the two levers most distinctive and decisive for accountability, and the **organised affected communities** for compensation. Each is a separate front, and a corrupt project that displaced communities, funded by a financier bound by anti-corruption rules, rarely escapes both prosecution and a fight for fair terms — even where it cannot be stopped. You do not have to choose one front: the same well-built file — the money trail, the audit, the record of displacement and unpaid compensation — can go to the auditors, the prosecutors, the financier's integrity unit, the international anti-fraud channels, the NGOs, and the press at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others. A Lesotho campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the prosecution of the corruption and the fight for compensation as the two that reach furthest when the project itself cannot be stopped.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly — and in Lesotho, honesty means distinguishing what can be stopped from what can only be held to account. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Lesotho and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project is **bound by treaty and a powerful neighbour** (which may put stopping out of reach), whether **corruption drove it** and can be proven, whether the **financier's rules** can be invoked, whether the **affected communities are organised** for compensation, and whether **international cooperation and attention** can be enlisted. Where corruption is provable and communities are organised, Lesotho's accountability and compensation levers are real, as the Highlands case showed; but temper every figure with the knowledge that the project itself may proceed.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Stopping a treaty-bound project	5-20%	years	low-moderate	Rare; the honest low baseline
Exposing & prosecuting corruption	30-55%	years	low	Officials and firms convicted
Financier debarment	30-55%	years	low	Corrupt contractors debarred
International legal cooperation	30-55%	years	low	Bribes traced; prosecutions enabled
Fighting for compensation & rights	30-55%	years	low	Fairer terms; resettlement; rehabilitation
Coalition of the affected	30-55%	ongoing	low	The claim organised and voiced
International attention & media	35-60%	ongoing	low	Scrutiny that strengthens every lever
All steps (corrupt, fundable project)	40-65%	2-8 years	low-moderate	Corruption punished; fairer terms won
All steps (aiming to stop)	15-40%	years	low-moderate	Usually delay, conditions, or accountability, not a stop

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Lesotho's real strengths are distinctive — **criminal accountability for corruption, financier debarment, international cooperation**, the **fight for compensation**, and the **world's attention**. Its constraint is stark and specific: a project **bound by treaty and a powerful neighbour may not be stoppable at all**, so the winnable fight is often accountability and terms, not prevention.

A note on cost: documenting the harm, exposing the corruption, and organising the affected cost little. Prosecutions and international cooperation are carried by the state and international bodies. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the patient documentation of the corruption and the harm, and the endurance to carry a prosecution and a compensation fight through years — exactly what the Highlands case required.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (stopped, or -- more often -- corruption punished, fair terms won)

CORRUPT + FUNDED PROJECT + ORGANISED COMMUNITIES + INTERNATIONAL SUPPORT:

Accountability + terms (all steps):	40-65%
Prosecute the corruption:	30-55%
Financier debarment:	30-55%
Compensation + rights:	30-55%
Single step:	5-60%

AIMING TO STOP A TREATY-BOUND PROJECT -- a powerful neighbour, foreign money:	
Stopping it:	5-20% <- the honest low baseline
Delay / conditions:	modest
Accountability instead:	the realistic, winnable goal
Single step:	5-20%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Lesotho are **the prosecution of corruption, the financier's debarment, and the fight for compensation**, amplified by international cooperation and attention. The Highlands case shows the ceiling for accountability: a poor country convicted the world's construction giants and its own official, and debarred them at the World Bank. But the same case shows the hard floor for stopping: the dams were built regardless. Most Lesotho fights over a major project are therefore not about whether it proceeds but about whether its corruption is punished and its victims made whole — and the honest lesson is that those are real, distinctive, and winnable, even when stopping is not. Read the table, then, as a corrective to a false choice: the failure to stop a project is not the failure of the campaign, because the campaign's realistic aims were always accountability and compensation, and by those measures the Highlands fight was a historic success. A community that judges itself only by whether the dam was built will feel defeated even in victory; one that judges itself by whether the corrupt were punished and the displaced fought for will see, in the same facts, a win worth every year it took.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Exposing and prosecuting the corruption** — Lesotho's most distinctive lever; the world's landmark example of convicting both corrupt officials and multinational contractors.
2. **Financier debarment** — pressing the World Bank and financiers to debar the corrupt firms, punishing them across every project, as with Acres and Lahmeyer.
3. **The fight for compensation and rights** — organising the affected communities to win fair compensation, resettlement, and rehabilitation where a project proceeds.
4. **International legal cooperation and attention** — the mutual legal assistance that traces bribes and the world's scrutiny that strengthens every lever.
5. **Documentation and the coalition** — the audit and evidence, and the united affected communities, that make accountability and the compensation claim possible.

What Lesotho Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Corruption can be punished** — a poor country convicted giants and its own CEO. **Financiers can be made to debar** — the World Bank debarred the corrupt firms. **International cooperation works** — Swiss and European help traced the bribes. **Compensation must be fought for** — the affected communities' struggle for fair terms is long and unfinished. **But treaty-bound projects may not be stopped** — the dams were built. The through-line: **document the harm and the corruption; expose and prosecute the bribery; press the financier to debar; organise the affected for compensation; and rouse the world — because in Lesotho, even a project you cannot stop can be made to answer for its corruption and to pay what it owes.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point, which in Lesotho is often the corruption or the compensation rather than the project itself. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the corruption that won the dam contracts, and the compensation the displaced highlanders are owed" is a case — the case Lesotho won. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **Can it be stopped, or only held to account?** This is the first, honest Lesotho question. Is the project **bound by treaty and a powerful neighbour**, effectively unstoppable — in which case the winnable fight is accountability and compensation — or is it a project a community can still hope to halt? Diagnose this early.
2. **Did corruption drive it?** Was the project, or its contracts, **corrupt** — bribes to officials, inflated costs, connected firms

— as the Highlands contracts were? Corruption is Lesotho's strongest lever, exposable and prosecutable.

3. What does it do to the communities, and what are they owed? What **displacement, loss of land and grazing, and harm** does it cause, and what **compensation, resettlement, and rehabilitation** are the affected people owed and not receiving?

4. Who finances it, and by what rules? Which **financiers** fund it, and are they bound by **anti-corruption and debarment rules** you can invoke, as the World Bank was at Highlands?

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which authority and contractors run it, who profits, who took bribes; which communities are affected; and which courts, financiers, international anti-fraud bodies, churches, NGOs, press, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a treaty-bound dam, run by an authority and multinational contractors and funded by a development bank, displaces highland communities — and its contracts were won by bribery.

Working the five questions: honestly, **can it be stopped**, or is it treaty-bound and only accountable? Did **corruption** drive the contracts — provable, prosecutable? What are the **displaced communities owed**? Which **financier** funds it, bound by what rules? And the deciders are the government, the authority, and the contractors, with the courts, the financier, international bodies, and the world as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "we oppose the dam" to a realistic target list: document the harm and the corruption; expose and prosecute the bribery; press the financier to debar; organise the affected for compensation; and rouse the world — aiming to stop it if you can, and to hold it to account and win fair terms if you cannot. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on what Lesotho achieved. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse and demoralising sense that nothing could be done into a short list of concrete, winnable tasks — document the corruption and the harm, demand an audit and a prosecution, press the financier to debar, organise for compensation — each tied to a specific lever, and none of them dependent on the impossible goal of stopping the project. That reframing, from prevention to accountability, is the difference the five questions make in Lesotho, and it is what turns despair into a plan.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, a financier's investigators, an international anti-fraud body, a journalist, and the world all move on evidence, not indignation — and Lesotho's landmark began with an **audit** that exposed the irregularities. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Contracts, the Money, and the Corruption

Get the documents the decision rests on, and above all **the money trail**. Obtain the **contracts, the payments, and the financial records**, and — as Lesotho's audit did — look for the **signs of corruption**: an official living beyond his means, payments through intermediaries, **secret foreign bank accounts**, inflated costs. Lesotho's case turned on exactly this — an audit that found irregularities, and civil proceedings that uncovered Swiss accounts. The lesson for documentation is precise: the corruption was not exposed by a whistle-blower's single dramatic revelation but by the patient, unglamorous work of auditing an authority's books and following a paltry, then a widening, trail of unexplained money — a lifestyle beyond a salary, a payment to an intermediary, an account in a foreign bank. A community that presses for a proper audit, and that helps document the visible signs of unexplained wealth, is doing the very thing that made the Highlands prosecutions possible. Obtain the **financier's rules** on corruption and debarment. The gap between what the paper claims — a clean, competitive, beneficial project — and what the money trail shows is where accountability cases are won.

Layer 2: The Harm to the Communities

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **displaced and affected communities** at the centre. Record the **displacement, the flooded valleys, the lost land and grazing, the ruined livelihoods, the resettlement and its failures** — the harm the Highlands dams did to the highland communities. Document **what the people were promised and what they received**, because the gap is the compensation claim. Record the **environmental harm** — the erosion, the changed rivers. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** from the displaced and the affected. Pay

particular attention to the gap between promise and delivery, because it is the core of the compensation claim: what were the affected people told they would receive — in land, in money, in resettlement, in restored livelihoods — and what did they actually get? A carefully documented record of that gap, village by village and family by family, is what converts a general grievance about unfair treatment into a specific, provable claim that an authority can be pressed and, if necessary, sued to meet.

Layer 3: The Corruption, the Harm, and What Is Owed

Finally, document the case for accountability and terms. Is there **provable corruption** — bribes, intermediaries, hidden accounts — as at Highlands? Does the project **breach the financier's anti-corruption rules**, grounds for **debarment**? Is the **compensation inadequate, delayed, or unmet**, and what are the affected people **owed** under the project's own commitments and the law? Each is a separate ground — for the prosecution, the debarment, the compensation claim, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Lesotho fights, because here a project sold as clean and beneficial is revealed to have been won by bribery, to breach the financier's rules, and to have left its displaced communities uncompensated — exactly the case Lesotho proved. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the corruption, the breach of the financier's rules, the unmet compensation — is that they reinforce one another and reach different deciders: the corruption drives the prosecution, the rule-breach drives the debarment, and the unmet compensation drives the claim for redress, so that a single well-built file opens three distinct fronts at once. A community that documents only the harm, or only the corruption, leaves the other levers unused; one that documents all three, as the Highlands fight in effect did, arms every part of the campaign from the same evidence.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Lesotho cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that prove the corruption, the harm, and what is owed.

The Contracts, the Money, and the Corruption Trail

- **The contracts and tenders** — how they were awarded, to whom, on what terms; the ground where corruption hides.
- **The financial records and payments** — the money trail, the intermediaries, and any signs of bribery, as Lesotho's audit and civil proceedings found.
- **The audit** — an independent audit of the authority and the project, which first exposed the Highlands corruption.
- **The financier's anti-corruption and debarment rules** — the standards the contractors must meet, and the grounds for debarment.
- **The contractors' records** — the multinational firms, their other projects, and any pattern of corruption elsewhere.

How to Get Them

Contract and financial records come through the authority, audits, and what access-to-information and court processes allow; the corruption trail through audits, investigators, and international cooperation; the financier's rules through the financier itself. Lean on **allies**: Lesotho's and the region's investigative journalists and anti-corruption bodies, international NGOs like International Rivers, and the international anti-fraud and mutual-legal-assistance channels — from Switzerland, from Europe — that traced the Highlands bribes. Move as evidence allows: an audit that exposes irregularities, and a financial trail that reaches foreign accounts, are what enable a prosecution and a debarment, as they did at Highlands. A practical note on sequencing: the audit tends to come first, because it is what surfaces the irregularities that justify a deeper investigation; the financial tracing follows, often requiring court orders and foreign cooperation to reach accounts abroad; and the debarment case is built on what the prosecution establishes. A campaign that understands this order can press for each step at the right moment — the audit now, the tracing as the audit bears fruit, the debarment as the convictions land — rather than demanding everything at once and diffusing its force.

The Ground Evidence

- **The displacement and harm** — the flooded land, the lost grazing, the ruined livelihoods, dated and photographed.
- **The compensation record** — what was promised, what was delivered, and the gap.
- **The resettlement evidence** — where people were moved, and whether it sustained them.
- **The environmental harm** — the erosion, the changed rivers, from study and testimony.
- **Testimony** — from the displaced, the affected, and those who know the highlands.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the contracts, the payments, the audit, the displacement, and the compensation — the spine of any prosecution, debarment, or compensation claim. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a villager, an auditor, a prosecutor, a financier's investigator, a journalist, and a judge all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the contractor or the authority pushes back. In a country where corruption can be prosecuted and financiers made to debar, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest money trail and the clearest record of the harm and what is owed — is very often the one that wins accountability and fair terms.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE COALITION OF THE AFFECTED

Evidence and law do not win on their own. Organised people do — and in Lesotho, the coalition of the affected communities and their allies is what turns exposed corruption and documented harm into accountability and fair terms. Even where the Highlands dams could not be stopped, organised communities, churches, and NGOs fought for compensation and rights and helped keep the corruption before the courts and the world. A Lesotho campaign's strength is that coalition, and its endurance through years.

Phase 1: The Core and the Affected

Start with a small, committed core drawn from and trusted by the **affected communities** — because their harm, their displacement, and their claim are the heart of the fight. Assign roles: documentation and money-trail liaison, community and compensation liaison, legal and prosecution liaison, financier and international liaison, and media. Agree on the goal — to stop the project if possible, and, if not, to **expose and prosecute the corruption, debar the contractors, and win fair compensation and rights** — and on what the communities will and will not accept. Set the realistic dual goal from the outset, and be honest with the communities about it, because a campaign that privately knows the dam cannot be stopped but publicly promises to stop it sets itself up to be seen as having failed. Far better to say plainly, from the first meeting, that the fight is to punish the corruption and win fair compensation — goals that are winnable and worth winning — so that the community measures itself against what it can achieve and stays united through the years the achievement takes.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **affected highland communities** across the project's reach, so they speak as one; the **churches**, which in Lesotho carry deep legitimacy and organised for the Highlands communities; the **anti-corruption and civil-society bodies**; sympathetic **lawyers, auditors, and investigators**; the **international NGOs** — International Rivers and others — that document dam harm and press financiers; and the **international anti-fraud and legal-cooperation channels** that can trace the bribes. Reach the **wider Basotho public** and the **international press**. The Highlands accountability drew on exactly this breadth — affected communities, churches, NGOs, prosecutors, and international cooperation as one — which is precisely the spread a winning Lesotho campaign needs. The churches deserve particular mention, because in Lesotho they carry a moral authority and an organisational reach that few other bodies can match, and they were central to organising and advocating for the highland communities affected by the dams. A campaign that has the churches with it has a network into every affected village and a legitimacy the authorities find hard to dismiss, and it should seek that alliance early and treat it as central, not peripheral.

A worked coalition example. Facing a corrupt, treaty-bound dam, the affected communities and churches form the base and carry the compensation fight; the auditors and investigators document the corruption; the prosecutors and international cooperation pursue the bribery; the international NGOs press the financier to debar; and the world's press carries the story. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the harm, the money, the prosecution, the financier, and the world — the model Lesotho used.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and a Lesotho accountability and compensation fight runs for years. Meet on a rhythm across the communities. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — an audit completed, a conviction won, a firm debarred, a compensation improvement, a wave of coverage. Keep the affected communities and

the churches at the centre, and guard against the split — the promise of jobs or partial payments to some — that an authority or contractor will use to divide the affected.

Phase 4: Showing Strength

Numbers and legitimacy must be seen. Let the **affected communities, the church leaders, and respected voices** speak, so the courts, the financier, and the world hear the united voice of the harmed, not a faction. Turn people out for hearings, for the documentation of harm, and for peaceful, dignified assertions of their claim. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the authority, the courts, the financier, and the world — that the affected communities are organised and will not relent until the corruption is punished and they are made whole, as Lesotho's communities pressed on for compensation long after the dams were built.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE COURTS, THE CORRUPTION, THE FINANCIER, AND COMPENSATION

Lesotho's law delivered the world's landmark corruption convictions, and its courts and the financiers' rules are powerful levers — for accountability and terms, if rarely for stopping a treaty-bound project. You do not need to halt a project to win: prosecuting the corruption, debarring the contractors, and forcing fair compensation are real victories. Engage lawyers, prosecutors, and NGOs early — but understand the tools.

Prosecuting the Corruption

The first and most distinctive lever is the **criminal prosecution of corruption**. Lesotho proved that its courts can **convict both a corrupt official and the multinational firms that bribed him** — its project CEO was imprisoned, and Canadian, German, French, and Italian firms were convicted or pleaded guilty. Build the case with the **audit, the money trail, and international cooperation**, and press the prosecuting authorities to pursue both the officials and the contractors. This is Lesotho's signature lever, and the world's model for holding a mega-project's corruption to account. A crucial feature of the Lesotho prosecutions is worth emphasising for any campaign that would follow them: the state pursued not only the official who took the bribes but the corporations that paid them, and it did so in its own courts, refusing the usual assumption that a poor country cannot take on wealthy foreign firms. That refusal is a choice a campaign can urge on its own prosecutors — to treat the bribe-payer as culpable as the bribe-taker, and to pursue the firm as vigorously as the man — and it is what elevated the Lesotho case from an ordinary corruption trial into a global precedent.

Financier Debarment

The second lever, distinctively powerful, is **debarment by the financier**. A development bank like the **World Bank** is bound by anti-corruption rules and can **debar** a contractor found corrupt — as it debarred Acres and Lahmeyer after the Lesotho convictions — barring it from future projects worldwide. Press the financier, with the evidence and the convictions, to debar the corrupt firms. This punishes them far beyond the single project and deters corruption across the industry.

The Fight for Compensation

The third lever is **compensation and rehabilitation**. Where a project proceeds, the affected communities are **owed compensation, resettlement, and rehabilitation** under the project's commitments and the law, and organised legal and civil pressure can force **fairer terms** where the authority has failed. This is the fight that continues after the dam is built, and it is real and winnable. It is also the fight most likely to matter to the people themselves, because for a displaced highland family a conviction in a distant court, however satisfying, does not replace the grazing land beneath a reservoir or the fields left behind in a resettlement. The compensation struggle is unglamorous and slow, turning on the details of what was promised, what was delivered, and what the law and the project's own commitments require, but it is where an organised community can, year by year, force the authority toward the fairer terms its people were owed.

International Cooperation and the Courts

Finally, the **international framework. Mutual legal assistance** — from Switzerland, from European anti-fraud bodies — can trace the bribes across borders and enable the prosecutions, as it did at Highlands, and international attention strengthens every claim. The domestic courts, which delivered the convictions, are a real lever for accountability, if a limited one for stopping.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Prosecutions go through the **Directorate of Public Prosecutions and the courts**; debarment through the **financier's anti-corruption mechanism**; compensation through **legal claims and pressure on the authority**; international help through the **mutual-legal-assistance and anti-fraud channels** and international NGOs. Get help early: Lesotho's and the region's anti-corruption lawyers and investigators, international NGOs like International Rivers, and the international cooperation channels know the corruption, the debarment, and the compensation routes. Help engaged as the evidence emerges is worth far more than help sought after — and in Lesotho, the strongest strategy marries the **prosecution of the corruption** to the **debarment of the contractors** and the **fight for compensation**.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a prosecutor, a financier, a court, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a dam contractor paid bribes through intermediaries into secret Swiss accounts to win a treaty-bound project that displaced highland communities without fair compensation. That one fact becomes:

- **A prosecution argument:** the contractor and the official committed bribery, provable through the money trail — the case Lesotho won.
- **A debarment argument (to the financier):** the contractor breached your anti-corruption rules and should be debarred — as Acres and Lahmeyer were.
- **A compensation argument:** a project won by corruption displaced our people without the fair terms they were owed — the claim for redress.
- **An international argument:** a mega-project's corruption crossed borders into foreign accounts — the case for mutual legal assistance and world attention.
- **A public argument:** they bribed their way to a dam that flooded our valleys and left us with nothing — the case that rouses the nation.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Lesotho the arguments that most often decide things are the **corruption** one, because it can be prosecuted and debarred, and the **compensation** one, because it wins redress for the harmed. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the money trail and a claim made to a court can be proven by the audit; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

Prosecutors and the courts want the corruption framed precisely against the law — the bribe, the intermediary, the account — with the audit and the money trail that prove it.

The financier responds to the breach of its own anti-corruption rules and the case for debarment, backed by the convictions.

International anti-fraud bodies respond to the cross-border money trail and the request for legal assistance.

Journalists need a specific, verified, striking story with a hook: a tiny kingdom convicting the world's construction giants, and displaced highlanders still fighting for compensation.

The public needs the argument simple and true: they bribed their way to our valleys and left us with nothing, and we made them pay.

The affected communities need to see that even an unstoppable project can be made to answer and to pay, so they hold together through the years of prosecution and the compensation fight. This is a real organising challenge, because the two goals move on different clocks: the prosecution may produce dramatic, visible milestones — an arrest, a conviction, a debarment — while the compensation fight grinds on quietly for years, and a community energised by the former can lose heart in the latter. Keeping both before the community, and marking progress on each, is how the coalition holds through the long stretch after the headlines fade, when the unglamorous work of winning fair terms is still to be done.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever. Coverage raises the cost of corruption, reaches the financier and the international community, and strengthens the compensation fight. Lesotho's landmark drew world attention precisely because it was so striking — a poor country convicting multinational giants — and that attention reinforced the debarments and the anti-corruption cause worldwide.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named project, a documented corruption, and a human cost. "A project was corrupt" is not a story; "a tiny kingdom convicted the world's construction giants of bribing their way to a dam that flooded highland valleys and displaced communities still fighting for compensation" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the bribes, the convictions, the displacement — and offer a human voice: a displaced villager, a church leader, an investigator. In Lesotho the story of a poor country holding the powerful to account, and of its displaced communities still seeking their due, is uniquely powerful.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Community and national voices** first. Then the **regional and international outlets** — because a small country convicting multinational firms and pressing their debarment is an international story that reinforces the accountability and reaches the financiers and the world. Then the **international NGO and anti-corruption networks**, which amplify the debarment and the compensation fight. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international ring is especially decisive** in Lesotho, because the corruption, the debarment, and the world's anti-corruption attention reach beyond a small country's borders. There is a particular reason the international story is strong here: the sheer improbability of it — one of the poorest countries in the world convicting some of the largest engineering firms in the world — is the kind of David-and-Goliath reversal that travels far, and it carries with it, wherever it is told, the useful message that no contractor is too powerful to be held to account. A Lesotho campaign should use that improbability deliberately, because it is exactly what makes editors and audiences abroad care.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and in Lesotho, the drumbeat must last through the prosecutions and the long compensation fight. Plan a sequence — the audit, the money trail, the convictions, the debarments, the compensation struggle — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the world and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; a corruption story especially demands precision, because one unproven claim can discredit the rest. Verified, specific, corruption-and-compensation-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that made Lesotho's accountability a model for the world.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the prosecutors, the financiers, the courts, and the international bodies. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the corruption, the harm, and what is owed.

8A. Demand for an Audit / Investigation

To: the auditor-general / the anti-corruption authority **Subject:** Request for audit and investigation of [project]

We, the affected communities of [place] and [coalition], request an **audit and investigation** of [project] and its authority. We have grounds to believe the contracts were **corrupt** — [an official living beyond his means, payments through intermediaries, unexplained wealth] — as was found in the Highlands Water Project. We attach our evidence and request a full audit of the contracts, payments, and financial records.

8B. Referral for Prosecution

To: the Directorate of Public Prosecutions **Subject:** Corruption in [project] — request for prosecution

We submit evidence that [official/contractor] engaged in **bribery** in [project]: [the money trail, the accounts, the intermediaries]. We ask that you prosecute both the **officials** and the **multinational contractors**, as Lesotho did in the Highlands case, convicting the project's CEO and the foreign firms. We attach our evidence and offer our full cooperation.

8C. Demand to the Financier for Debarment

To: the World Bank / development bank (anti-corruption / integrity unit) **Subject:** Debar [contractor] for corruption in [project]

We write regarding [contractor], which won contracts in [project] you financed through **bribery** — [the evidence / the convictions]. This breaches your anti-corruption rules. We request that you **debar** [contractor], as you debarred Acres International and Lahmeyer after the Lesotho Highlands convictions, barring it from your future projects. We attach our evidence.

8D. Compensation Claim / Demand to the Authority

To: the development authority / the government **Subject:** Fair compensation and rehabilitation for [community]

We, the displaced and affected people of [place], demand the **fair compensation, resettlement, and rehabilitation** we are owed for [project]. We were promised [X] and received [Y]; the gap, and the harm to our land, grazing, and livelihoods, are documented and attached. We require that the authority meet its obligations, as the Highlands communities have demanded of theirs.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Anti-Corruption NGO

To: an anti-corruption lawyer / International Rivers-type NGO **Subject:** [Project] — corruption, debarment, and compensation

We believe [project] was corrupt and has left our communities uncompensated. We attach the contracts, the money trail, the audit, and our evidence of harm, and seek advice on **prosecuting the corruption, pressing the financier to debar** the contractors, **claiming compensation**, and engaging **international cooperation**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8F. Request for International Legal Assistance

To: [foreign anti-fraud body / mutual-legal-assistance channel] **Subject:** [Project] corruption — request to trace cross-border payments

We are pursuing corruption in [project] in Lesotho. The evidence points to **bribes paid across borders** into [foreign accounts], as in the Highlands case, where Swiss and European cooperation traced the payments. We ask for your assistance in tracing the cross-border payments and supporting the prosecution. We attach our evidence.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the corruption / the community]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something the world should know, with a clear hook: [documents and the money trail] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a dam contractor bribed its way to a treaty-bound project that flooded highland valleys, and our people are still fighting for compensation"]. It echoes how Lesotho convicted the world's construction giants. I can share the full file and connect you with a displaced villager and an investigator. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** Make [project] answer for its corruption and pay what it owes

We, the affected people of [place], declare that though [project] was forced upon us, it will **answer for its corruption and pay what it owes**. Its contracts were won by bribery; our valleys were flooded; our compensation is unpaid. We call on the prosecutors, the financiers, and the world to hold it to account, as Lesotho held the Highlands giants, and we will

not relent until the corrupt are punished and our people made whole.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a demand for an audit, a referral for prosecution, or a debarment request is itself evidence, and exactly what the prosecutors, financiers, and international bodies will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the corruption, the harm, and what is owed; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the coalition, the churches, the anti-corruption bodies and international NGOs, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in Lesotho that record feeds the levers that matter most: the prosecution of corruption, the financier's debarment, and the fight for compensation.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a corrupt project — and win redress. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Follow the money and document the corruption.** In Lesotho, the corruption is the strongest lever. Look for the signs — unexplained wealth, intermediaries, foreign accounts — and document them (Step 2).
- 2. Demand an audit and a prosecution.** Push the auditor and the prosecutors to investigate and prosecute the corruption, officials and contractors alike (8A, 8B) — as Lesotho did.
- 3. Press the financier to debar.** Demand the World Bank or the financier debar the corrupt contractors (8C), as it debarred Acres and Lahmeyer.
- 4. Organise the affected for compensation.** Bring the displaced together and claim the fair compensation and rehabilitation they are owed (8D).
- 5. Seek international cooperation.** Ask the foreign anti-fraud and legal-assistance channels to trace cross-border bribes (8F).
- 6. Reach the anti-corruption NGOs and the press.** International Rivers-type NGOs and a striking corruption story (8E, 8G) amplify every lever.
- 7. Be honest about stopping.** If the project is treaty-bound, aim your strength at accountability and compensation, not a stop you cannot win (Step 1).

Do only the first three and you will have documented the corruption, pushed for prosecution, and sought debarment — the exact foundation of Lesotho's landmark. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: follow the money, demand prosecution, press the financier to debar. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, done early, put the decisive Lesotho levers into play — the money trail that proves the corruption, the prosecution that punishes it, and the debarment that carries the punishment across the whole industry — and they are within reach of a handful of determined people with an eye for unexplained wealth and the persistence to demand an audit.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Lesotho's system is tilted in a specific and sobering way, and you must understand it, so you neither waste effort chasing an unwinnable stop nor miss the accountability levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is structural. Lesotho is **small, poor, and water-rich**, bound to a **treaty with a far more powerful neighbour** whose industrial heartland depends on its water — so the largest projects are effectively **beyond its power to stop**. The **state is weak**, dependent on the project's revenue and on its neighbour. **Compensation** for the displaced is chronically **inadequate and delayed**. And the affected communities are **remote and poor**. Where these tilts bite — above all in the impossibility of stopping a treaty-bound project — a campaign aimed only at prevention will fail. The answer is to aim at what can be won: accountability and terms.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, real and distinctive levers remain.

The corruption can still be prosecuted. Lesotho proved a poor country can convict its own officials and the world's construction giants — an accountability no treaty prevents.

The financier can still debar. A development bank bound by anti-corruption rules can be made to debar the corrupt, punishing them across every project.

International cooperation still traces the bribes. Foreign anti-fraud and legal-assistance channels can follow the money across borders.

Compensation can still be fought for and improved. Organised communities can force fairer terms even where the project proceeds.

The world still watches. A poor country holding the powerful to account, and its displaced still seeking their due, draws attention that strengthens every lever.

This attention is a genuine asset in a way it is not everywhere: because the Lesotho case became internationally famous, a new corruption exposed in a Lesotho project inherits a ready-made frame and a watching audience, and campaigners, journalists, and anti-corruption bodies abroad already understand and care about the pattern. A community can invoke that legacy deliberately, presenting its own fight as the next chapter of a story the world already knows and admires.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Lesotho is sobering but not defeatist: a treaty-bound, neighbour-serving mega-project may not be stoppable, and to pretend otherwise wastes a community's strength — but its corruption can be punished, its contractors debarred, and its victims fought for, and that is a real and, in Lesotho's case, world-leading form of resistance. So diagnose your fight honestly: judge whether the project can be **stopped** or only **held to account**; if the latter, **expose and prosecute the corruption, press the financier to debar, organise for compensation, and enlist international cooperation and attention** — and take pride that this, too, is a victory, and one the world learned from Lesotho. There is dignity as well as strategy in this reframing: a community that cannot save its valley but can put the men and firms who corruptly flooded it in the dock, and can force the fair compensation its people were denied, has not been merely a victim but an agent of justice — and Lesotho's example, studied and admired around the world, is proof that such agency is possible even for the poor and the small against the rich and the powerful.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Lesotho, corruption is not a side-issue; it is the very thing the country's landmark fight exposed and punished, so this section is the heart of the guide. When a project is driven by bribery — contracts won through payments to officials, as the Highlands contracts were — your whole strategy is the exposure and prosecution of that corruption.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of corruption, which the Highlands case laid bare. An **official living far beyond his means** — the housing, the cars, the holidays — as the audit found of the project's CEO; **payments through intermediaries; secret foreign bank accounts**, as the Swiss accounts revealed; **inflated costs** and **contracts awarded** to firms with a **pattern of corruption elsewhere**, as several Highlands contractors had. Trace the money and the lifestyle: who profits, who decided, whose wealth cannot be explained. In Lesotho, a major project won by such means is not an aberration but exactly what the Highlands prosecutions uncovered — and exactly what can be proven and punished. The reassuring implication for a community that suspects corruption but fears it can never be proven is that the signs are often visible from the outside, long before any account is subpoenaed: a modest official's sudden prosperity, a contract awarded against the evident merits, a firm already notorious for corruption elsewhere. These visible signs are enough to justify demanding an audit, and the audit is enough to justify the investigation, and so the chain that ends in a conviction begins with something an ordinary observer can notice and document.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Officials, an authority, and parts of the state** can be captured by the money. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **courts**, which convicted the corrupt; the **financiers' integrity units**, bound by anti-corruption rules; the **international anti-fraud and legal-assistance bodies**; the **auditors and investigators**; the **churches, civil society, and international NGOs**; and the **world's press**. Lesotho showed that even the powerful multinational firms are not beyond a determined prosecution. Capture thrives in secrecy; your task is to lift the money trail into the light — into the audit, the court, the financier, and the world. What makes this achievable, even against wealthy and well-defended firms, is that corruption leaves a trail: the bribe has to move, from payer to intermediary to recipient, and it has to be hidden somewhere, in an account, a property, a lifestyle that outruns a salary. Every one of those movements is a potential piece of evidence, and the Lesotho case was built precisely by following them — which is why a campaign should think of the corruption not as an impenetrable secret but as a trail waiting to be traced, with the right audit, the right court order, and the right international cooperation.

What to Do

Do not assume the corruption cannot be touched. Instead, **document it precisely** — the unexplained wealth, the intermediaries, the accounts, the inflated contracts — and take it to the forces that can act: the **auditors and prosecutors**, as Lesotho did; the **financier's integrity unit**, for debarment; the **international anti-fraud channels**, to trace the cross-border money; and the **world**. Pair the exposure with the fight for the **compensation** the corruption stole from the displaced, so the impropriety and the harm surface together. In Lesotho, exposing and prosecuting the corruption is not a side-argument; it is the central, world-leading achievement — the proof that a poor country can convict the powerful and make a mega-project's corruption pay, even when it cannot stop the project itself.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together, over years. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Lesotho turns on the corruption, the debarment, and the fight for compensation.

Early (Months 0-12): The Money, the Harm, and the Audit

Pin down the project, and honestly whether it can be **stopped or only held to account** (Step 1); document the **corruption trail and the harm** (Step 2). Build the **core and the coalition of the affected** (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **demand an audit and investigation** (8A); **document the money trail** and the displacement; **organise the affected for compensation** (8D); and reach the **anti-corruption bodies, NGOs, and a lawyer** (8E). This phase lays the foundation, and in Lesotho the audit and the money trail begun here are what enable everything after.

Middle (Years 1-5): Prosecution, Debarment, and Compensation

Sustain the coalition (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **prosecution** of officials and contractors (8B), the **debarment** by the financier (8C), the **international cooperation** to trace the bribes (8F), and the **compensation claim** pressed on the authority (8D). Reach the **international NGOs and the press** (8G). Build the media drumbeat from national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — the audit and the tracing of the money before trails go cold — because those chances do not return. The tracing of cross-border payments is especially time-sensitive, because accounts can be closed, records destroyed, and the cooperation of foreign authorities is easier to secure while a matter is live and prominent than years later; the Highlands prosecutions depended on assistance from Swiss and European bodies in following the money abroad, and a campaign should seek that international cooperation early, while the trail is fresh and the attention high.

Later (Years 2-10+): Accountability Won, Compensation Pursued

Win the accountability — **convictions, debarments** — as Lesotho did, and pursue the **compensation** long after, because the fight for fair terms outlasts the prosecutions. And, where the project could not be stopped, take the honest measure of the win: not a project prevented, but its corruption punished and its victims fought for. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is convictions, debarments, and improved compensation, as at Highlands. Sometimes it is a long, partial struggle for redress. Both are real, and in Lesotho they are the winnable fight. And there is a further, quieter value in pursuing them even when the project proceeds: a documented, prosecuted, internationally noted case of corruption raises the cost and the risk of the next such project, deterring some of the bribery that would otherwise be treated as routine, and a community that wins fair compensation sets a precedent the next displaced community can invoke. The win, in other words, outlasts the single fight, strengthening the hand of everyone who comes after.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-12	Diagnose stop-or-account Document corruption + harm Demand audit Organise the affected
YEARS 1-5	Prosecute officials + contractors Debarment International cooperation Compensation claim Media
YEARS 2-10+	Convictions + debarments won Pursue compensation Take honest measure of the win

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Lesotho gives communities a genuinely powerful — and, because a project may be unstoppable, distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **The criminal prosecution of corruption** — of officials and of the world's multinational contractors — is Lesotho's landmark gift to the world, the proof that a poor country can convict the powerful. Before Lesotho, the received wisdom was that the corporations behind corrupt megaprojects were effectively untouchable in the countries they operated in, shielded by their wealth, their lawyers, and the dependence of poor governments on their contracts; the Lesotho prosecutions overturned that wisdom, and every campaign since that has sought to hold a contractor criminally to account has stood on the ground Lesotho cleared. **Financier debarment** punishes the corrupt across every project. **International legal cooperation** traces the bribes across borders. The **fight for compensation** wins redress for the displaced. And the **world's attention** strengthens every lever. These are the tools that let a tiny kingdom hold the Highlands giants to account.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them from the first page. The dams **were built**; a treaty-bound, neighbour-serving project may simply be **beyond a small country's power to stop**. **Compensation is chronically inadequate**, and the fight for it long. And accountability, however historic, **does not undo** the flooded valleys and the lost livelihoods. No guide should pretend these away; in Lesotho, the art is to win what can be won — accountability and terms — where stopping cannot be. This is not a lesser ambition dressed up as a virtue; it is a clear-eyed recognition of where a small country's power actually lies. The Highlands communities could not command the treaty or the neighbour, but they could — through their courts, their auditors, their churches, and their allies abroad — command a reckoning, and a reckoning is what they got. To aim there is not to settle; it is to aim where the shot can land.

So the realistic promise is this: **judge honestly whether the project can be stopped or only held to account; document the corruption and the harm; expose and prosecute the bribery; press the financier to debar; organise the affected for compensation; and enlist international cooperation and attention — running all of it together**. None of these steps requires wealth, and none requires the power to command a treaty or a neighbour; each requires only evidence, organisation, and endurance, which are within the reach of a determined community and its allies. That is why the Lesotho model travels: it was built not by a rich or powerful country but by a poor and small one, using tools — an audit, a court, a financier's rules, an international channel, an organised community — available to almost anyone willing to use them. Do that, and against a corrupt, financed project, you can convict the corrupt, debar the contractors, and win fairer terms for the displaced, as Lesotho did; against a treaty-bound project you cannot stop, you can still make its corruption pay and fight for its victims. Do it as Lesotho did — a poor kingdom that, unable to refuse a mega-project imposed by treaty and its powerful neighbour, put the world's construction giants and its own official in the dock, won, and pressed on for its displaced people.

A last word on what victory means where a project cannot be stopped. Lesotho's lesson is that accountability is itself a form of resistance — that when the powerful cannot be prevented, they can still be made to answer, and their victims fought for — and that this, done well, can be world-leading. The powerful count on your despair, on the treaty that binds you, on the belief that a small poor country can do nothing against giants. Their advantage is the treaty, the money, and the neighbour. Those advantages are real, and they will not be wished away: the treaty binds, the money talks, and the neighbour's need is permanent, so a community that stakes everything on cancelling the project stakes everything on losing. But none of those advantages protects a corrupt official or a bribe-paying firm from a court, none of them exempts a contractor from a financier's rules, and none of them cancels the compensation the displaced are owed — which is why the fight, aimed correctly, is winnable even against opponents who hold every card that matters for stopping the dam. Yours is a set of courts that convicted those giants, financiers who must debar the corrupt, an international system that traces the bribes, and the proven fact that Lesotho did all of this. Play to that. Keep the money trail and the record of harm, keep the corruption and the compensation at the centre, keep the affected communities united, prosecute the bribery, debar the contractors, and treat every audit, every conviction, every debarment, and every compensation claim as a brick in a wall no corrupt giant can climb.

The tools are here, and Lesotho itself proved them: a tiny kingdom convicted the world's construction giants and its own official of the corruption behind a mega-dam, debarred them at the World Bank, and stood by its displaced communities in their fight for what they were owed. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, honesty about what can be won,

and a people who refuse to let the powerful escape accountability even when they cannot escape the project itself — and those you supply, along with the proof, in Lesotho, that the giants can be made to answer. Begin today, begin with the money trail and the harm, and build from there. Start with what you can see and document without permission from anyone — the unexplained wealth, the contract that does not add up, the promises made to the displaced and never kept — and let that documentation be the seed from which the audit, the prosecution, the debarment, and the compensation claim all grow, exactly as they grew, in the Highlands, from an audit that simply asked where the money had gone. Communities before you have made the powerful answer for what they could not prevent — the corrupt convicted in open court, the giants debarred by the bank, the displaced fighting on for their rightful due. What was won in the Lesotho Highlands can be won again. So can yours. A poor mountain kingdom, told it could do nothing against a treaty, a bank, and the world's great construction firms, proved otherwise — not by stopping the dam, which it could not, but by making the corruption behind it answer in open court and standing by the people it displaced. That is the resistance available to you when prevention is not, and the method behind it, and the proof that it works, are now yours to use.